

Banff, Yoho → Jasper Loop

4 BASE CAMPS

AUG 18 - 27, 2026 · YYC ROUND TRIP

BASE 01

Canmore, AB

Aug 18 - 21

3 Nights

Banff town · Lake
Minnewanka · Lake
Louise · Moraine Lake

BASE 02

Golden, BC

Aug 21 - 23

2 Nights

Yoho NP · Emerald Lake
· Takakkaw Falls ·
Natural Bridge

BASE 03

Valemount, BC

Aug 23 - 26

3 Nights

Mount Robson · Jasper
day trips · Maligne Lake ·
Pyramid Lake

BASE 04

Calgary Airport Area

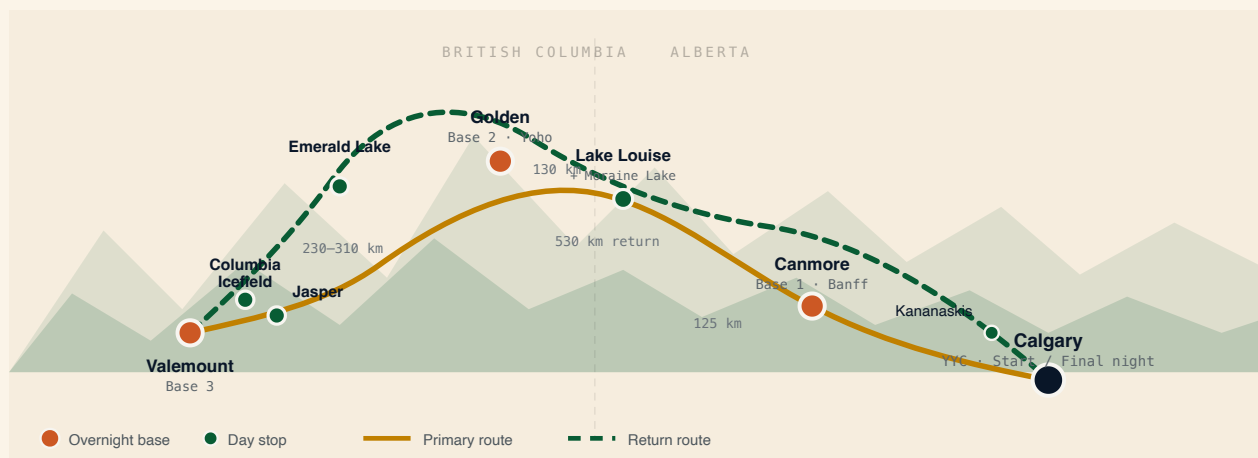
Aug 26 - 27

1 Night

Positioning night · easy
YYC rental return · fly
out without the long
drive

THE ROUTE

Calgary → Canmore → Golden → Valemount → Calgary



LEG	KM	EST. TIME	HIGHWAY
Calgary YYC → Canmore	125 km	~1.5 hr	Hwy 2 N → Trans-Canada Hwy 1 W
Canmore → Golden	130 km	1.5–2.5 hr + stops	Hwy 1 W through Lake Louise and Kicking Horse Pass
Golden → Valemount	~360–390 km	5–6 hr + stops	Hwy 1 E → Icefields Parkway / Hwy 93 N → Hwy 16 W
Valemount ↔ Jasper	120 km each way	~1.5 hr each way	Yellowhead Hwy 16 through Mount Robson
Valemount → Calgary airport area	~530 km	6.5–7.5 hr + stops	Hwy 16 E → Hwy 93 S → Hwy 1 E → Hwy 2 S
Calgary hotel → YYC	5–20 km	10–25 min	Airport-area local roads
Total trip driving	~1,300+ km	~18–22 hr	Long drive moved to Aug 26, not departure day



TUESDAY, AUGUST 18, 2026

Calgary Arrival → Canmore

125 km • ~1.5 hr • Return rental YYC → YYC

● **Fly into Calgary YYC** Morning

Collect luggage and pick up the SUV rental at YYC. This is now a round-trip rental, so confirm the Calgary return location and keep the reservation simple.

● **Calgary grocery stop** ~30 min

Stock snacks, breakfast items, water, sunscreen, and trail food before heading west. Grocery options are easy in Canmore, but Calgary is the lowest-friction first stop.

● **Drive to Canmore** Afternoon

Take Hwy 2 north, then Trans-Canada Hwy 1 west. The first big mountain reveal comes as the Bow Valley opens near Canmore.

- **Check into Canmore Airbnb** Evening

Settle into the first base. Walk Main Street, confirm shuttle and Pursuit reservations, and keep the first night easy.

BOOK BEFORE YOU GO

Prioritize Moraine Lake shuttle, Maligne Lake Cruise, Columbia Icefield, Banff Gondola, Lake Minnewanka Cruise, and the Canmore, Golden, and Valemount Airbnb check-in details. August is peak season.

DAY

2

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 19, 2026

Lake Louise + Moraine Lake

Canmore base • shuttle day • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Lake Louise Park & Ride** Early morning

Drive to the Lake Louise Ski Resort Park & Ride and check in for your reserved Parks Canada shuttle. Use the connector to see both Lake Louise and Moraine Lake in one day.

- **Moraine Lake — Rockpile viewpoint** Morning

Start with the Valley of Ten Peaks while light is clean and crowds are lower. Rockpile is the essential short walk; canoe rentals are optional if the line is reasonable.

- **Lake Louise lakeshore or Tea House hike** Midday

For a lighter day, walk the lakeshore to Victoria Glacier views. For stronger hikers, Lake Agnes Tea House is the best upgrade.

- **Johnston Canyon on the return** Late afternoon

If the group has energy, stop for the Lower and Upper Falls catwalk trail. If not, save Johnston Canyon as a flexible backup for Day 3.

MORAINE LAKE LOGISTICS

Personal vehicles are not permitted on Moraine Lake Road. Use Parks Canada shuttle, Roam transit, or a licensed commercial operator; reserve early and set an alarm for released seats.

THURSDAY, AUGUST 20, 2026

DAY

3

Banff Town + Lake Minnewanka

Local Banff loop • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Banff Gondola — Sulphur Mountain**

Morning • Pursuit Pass

Ride to the summit boardwalk for the cleanest panoramic view of the Bow Valley. Book a morning slot and leave time for parking or shuttle logistics.

- **Banff Avenue + Bow Falls**

Midday

Lunch in Banff, then walk to Bow Falls for an easy river viewpoint. This keeps the day scenic without overloading it after the lake day.

- **Lake Minnewanka Cruise or shoreline**

Afternoon • Pursuit Pass option

Use the cruise if it is part of your pass and schedule; otherwise the shoreline viewpoint and Two Jack Lake drive are worthwhile on their own.

- **Pack for Yoho / Golden**

Evening

Tomorrow crosses the Continental Divide. Confirm Golden Airbnb check-in and make sure fuel, snacks, and offline maps are set.

DAY

4

FRIDAY, AUGUST 21, 2026

Canmore → Golden

130 km • 1.5-2.5 hr + Yoho stops

- **Scenic drive over Kicking Horse Pass**

Morning

Leave Canmore after breakfast and head west past Lake Louise into Yoho. The drive is short enough to make the transfer day feel like sightseeing, not a slog.

- **Spiral Tunnels viewpoint**

Quick stop

Classic railway engineering stop on the Trans-Canada. Worth a short pullout if visibility is good and timing is easy.

- **Natural Bridge + Emerald Lake**

Afternoon

Natural Bridge is a fast, high-value stop. Emerald Lake is the anchor: walk part of the shoreline, rent canoes if conditions are calm, and linger here.

- **Check into Golden Airbnb**

Evening

Golden gives you the right mix of lodging, food options, and access to Yoho. Keep dinner local and avoid adding another long detour.

DAY

5

SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026

Yoho National Park

Golden base • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Takakkaw Falls**

Morning • seasonal road

One of the signature waterfall stops in the Rockies. The access road is seasonal and winding, so check current conditions before committing the morning.

- **Emerald Lake second pass or Iceline trail**

Midday

Keep the default easy: more Emerald Lake time, lunch, and short walks. If the group wants a serious hiking day, choose an Iceline segment instead.

- **Wapta Falls or Golden Skybridge**

Afternoon

Wapta Falls is the nature-forward pick. Golden Skybridge is the Pursuit-style paid attraction option if the group wants something structured.

- **Early night before Jasper transfer**

Evening

Tomorrow is the biggest scenery day of the trip. Fuel up, pack the car plan, and confirm Columbia Icefield reservation timing.

WHY GOLDEN WORKS

Golden is the efficient Yoho base: Emerald Lake, Natural Bridge, Takakkaw Falls, Wapta Falls, and town amenities are all close enough for a full but manageable local day.

DAY

6

SUNDAY, AUGUST 23, 2026

Golden → Valemount

Icefields Parkway + Mount Robson • 5-6 hr driving + stops

- **Bow Lake + Peyto Lake** Morning

Return east to Lake Louise, then turn north onto the Icefields Parkway. Bow Lake is the first easy shoreline stop; Peyto Lake is the quick high-reward viewpoint.

- **Columbia Icefield Adventure + Skywalk** Midday • Pursuit Pass

Time the reservation so the day does not get rushed. This is the best place to use the bigger-ticket Pursuit attraction on the transfer north.

- **Sunwapta Falls + Athabasca Falls** Afternoon

Both are natural breaks before Jasper town. If time gets tight, prioritize Athabasca Falls for the shortest, strongest stop.

- **Jasper supply stop, then Valemount Airbnb** Evening

Pick up any groceries or dinner in Jasper before continuing west on Hwy 16. Valemount is about 120 km from Jasper, so arrive with the next day's plan already set.

VALEMOUNT BASE REALITY CHECK

Valemount is a workable Jasper access base, but not a Jasper town stay. Budget about 1.5 hours each way to Jasper before adding Maligne Lake, Pyramid Lake, or town activities.

DAYS

7-8

MONDAY-TUESDAY, AUGUST 24-25, 2026

Valemount Base + Jasper Day Trips

120 km / ~1.5 hr each way to Jasper

AUG 24 — MALIGNE ROAD

- **Medicine Lake viewpoint** Morning

Drive Maligne Road slowly and watch for wildlife. Medicine Lake is the best low-effort stop before continuing to Maligne Lake.

- **Maligne Lake Cruise** Book ahead • Pursuit Pass option

Use this as the anchor for the Jasper stay. Spirit Island is the postcard view, and the drive itself is part of the experience.

- **Jasper town dinner** Evening

AUG 25 — FLEXIBLE JASPER DAY

- **Pyramid Lake + Patricia Lake** Half day

Easy, beautiful, and close to town. Walk Pyramid Island, rent paddles if conditions are calm, or keep it as a recovery morning.

- **Jasper SkyTram or Miette Hot Springs** Choose one

SkyTram is the view-focused option if running and included in your package. Miette is the softer recovery day if the group wants a break.

Keep the evening light after the longer lake road. Walk Connaught Drive and watch for elk around town.

- **Athabasca River valley + stargazing**

Evening

Use clear nights for dark-sky viewing. Jasper is at its best when the itinerary leaves room for weather, wildlife, and slower moments.

USE VALEMOUNT STRATEGICALLY

Do one big Jasper/Maligne day and one flexible Jasper town, Pyramid Lake, Mount Robson, or recovery day. The long return drive moves to Aug 26 so departure day stays easy.

DAY

9

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026

Valemount → Calgary Positioning Night

~530 km • 6.5–7.5 hr + stops • Sleep near YYC

- **Early checkout from Valemount**

Morning

Make this the long travel day instead of departure day. Check DriveBC and 511 Alberta before leaving, then head east through Mount Robson and Jasper.

- **Short scenic stops only**

Flexible

Use this direction for any quick missed stops: Mount Robson viewpoint, Athabasca Falls, Saskatchewan River Crossing, Bow Lake, or Peyto Lake. Keep the stops disciplined so the day does not stretch too late.

- **Check into Calgary airport-area hotel**

Evening

Stay near YYC or along the north side of Calgary. This removes the stressful mountain drive from flight day and makes the rental return straightforward.

WHY THIS WORKS BETTER

The long Valemount-to-Calgary drive still exists, but it no longer competes with airport timing. Aug 27 becomes a short local transfer instead of a 7-hour mountain drive.

DAY

10

THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2026

Calgary → Fly Out

- **Slow morning near YYC** Flight dependent

Breakfast, final packing, and a short local drive. No mountain highway pressure on departure day.

- **Return SUV at Calgary YYC** Per flight schedule

Allow the normal airport buffer for rental return, bag drop, and security. The route is now simple enough for morning, midday, or evening flights.

DEPARTURE DAY

This is now intentionally boring: short drive, rental return, airport. That is the point.

QUICK REFERENCE

Must-See Highlights + Trip Tips

Moraine Lake

Valley of Ten Peaks, accessed by shuttle or licensed operator. This is the most important reservation in the Banff portion.

Lake Louise

Pair the lakeshore with Moraine Lake, or upgrade to Lake Agnes Tea House if the group wants a moderate hike.

Emerald Lake

The Yoho anchor. Less urban than Banff, easier to linger, and a strong reason to keep the Golden base.

Takakkaw Falls

High-impact waterfall stop in Yoho. Check seasonal road status before relying on it for the day.

Columbia Icefield

The best transfer-day anchor between Yoho and Jasper: glacier, Skywalk, and huge Icefields Parkway scenery.

Maligne Lake

Jasper's signature lake day. From Valemount, make this one intentional full day rather than a casual add-on.

PARK ADMISSION

Your dates fall inside Parks Canada's 2026 free-admission window, but shuttle tickets, paid

PURSUIT PASS COVERAGE

Confirm the exact 2026 package. Likely candidates: Banff Gondola, Lake Minnewanka

parking, tours, and attraction reservations still need to be booked separately.

Cruise, Columbia Icefield, Maligne Lake Cruise, and Golden Skybridge.

JASPER CLOSURES

Do not build the plan around Maligne Canyon or Edith Cavell for 2026. Parks Canada lists those areas closed while recovery work continues.

PRE-TRIP BOOKING CHECKLIST

Moraine Lake shuttle · Maligne Lake Cruise · Columbia Icefield · Banff Gondola · Lake Minnewanka Cruise · Canmore, Golden, and Valemount Airbnbs · Calgary airport-area hotel · YYC round-trip SUV.

AUGUST WEATHER + PACKING

Warm days, cool nights, fast weather changes. Pack shell jackets, layers, sunscreen, water bottles, bug spray, and footwear that can handle wet trails.

DRIVING + FUEL NOTES

Top off in Canmore, Golden, Jasper, and Valemount. Keep offline maps for Yoho, Icefields Parkway, Hwy 16, Maligne Road, and the Aug 26 Valemount-to-Calgary return.